Human need

The human race has used trees from its earliest days. In Neolithic times, they were cut down for fuel and to construct shelters and fencing. Five-thousand-year-old stone axes for chopping wood have been found, as well as ax factories from the same era in Europe and North America. During the Middle Ages, however, as human populations expanded rapidly in western Europe between 1100 and 1500, extensive deforestation took place. Forests were cleared to make way for agriculture, and wood was used to build homes and boats, and to make bows, tools, and other implements.

Trees were cut down on an industrial scale in central Europe and England to produce charcoal, which became an important fuel (until replaced by coal) because it burns at higher temperatures than wood. An early example of sustainable production was practiced in England, where many woods were managed as coppices whose trees were partially cut back and then allowed to regrow to create a cyclical supply of charcoal. Even so, by the 17th century England had to import wood for shipbuilding from the Baltic nations and New England in the US.

Primeval forest clearance accelerated globally between 1850 and 1920, with the biggest losses in North America, the Russian empire, and South Asia. In the 20th century, the focus shifted to the tropics, especially to tropical rainforest, half of which has been destroyed since 1947, with the proportion of the land that it covers having fallen from 14 percent to 6 percent.

It is estimated that, each year, 10 million hectares (approximately equivalent to the size of Iceland) of forest are cut down. This has led to estimates that Earth has lost one-third of its forest. Some regions have been hit harder than others. Currently, 95 percent of deforestation is occurring in the tropics. For example, since Europeans arrived in Brazil, over 80 percent